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Original Page: 186**Culture (OWC):** [Khoi \(FX13\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1973-1983**Coverage Date:** 1880-1990**Place Coverage:** South Africa And Namibia**Section Title(S):** Nama Kinship • Relationship Terminology

Nama kinship

One of the most common morphemes in the Nama language is *khoe* ('person'), which is used in constructions meaning 'friend', 'friendly', etc., and has a number of kinship meanings as well. Hahn (1882) noted *khoei-si-ga-gu* (his orthography) for 'to be married'; Kroenlein (1889: 209–10) recorded *khoixa* ('related'), *khoixagu* ('to be related to each other'), *khoixakhoin* (meaning loosely either 'blood relatives' or 'friends'), etc. I have also found this last term in use for 'kinsfolk' (modern orthography, *khoexa khoen*, literally 'people with people'). Related terms in other Khoe languages generally carry the meaning 'spouse'. Nama do not seem to dwell on the idea of universal kinship classification in the way that Bushmen do, but instead emphasize patrilineal links, links through name lines, and close cognatic ties, all of which signify the *khoexa* relationship.

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Relationship terminology

The Nama relationship terminology has a very similar structure to that of the Korana. The basic structure is shown in Figure 10.3. The terminology is complicated by the fact that there are often a number of terms for the same genealogical position. Such terms are distinguished by linguistic and social, rather than genealogical, context. More specifically, the choice of term is governed by the grammatical person of ego (whether ego is speaker, e.g., 'my mother', or referent, e.g., 'your mother' or 'his mother') and by the level of formality required. For reasons of space, only the most common terms are presented here, but a full list of indigenous terms is included in Table 16.2 (Chapter 16).

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Senior cross-relatives are termed *//nao-*, while junior cross-relatives and

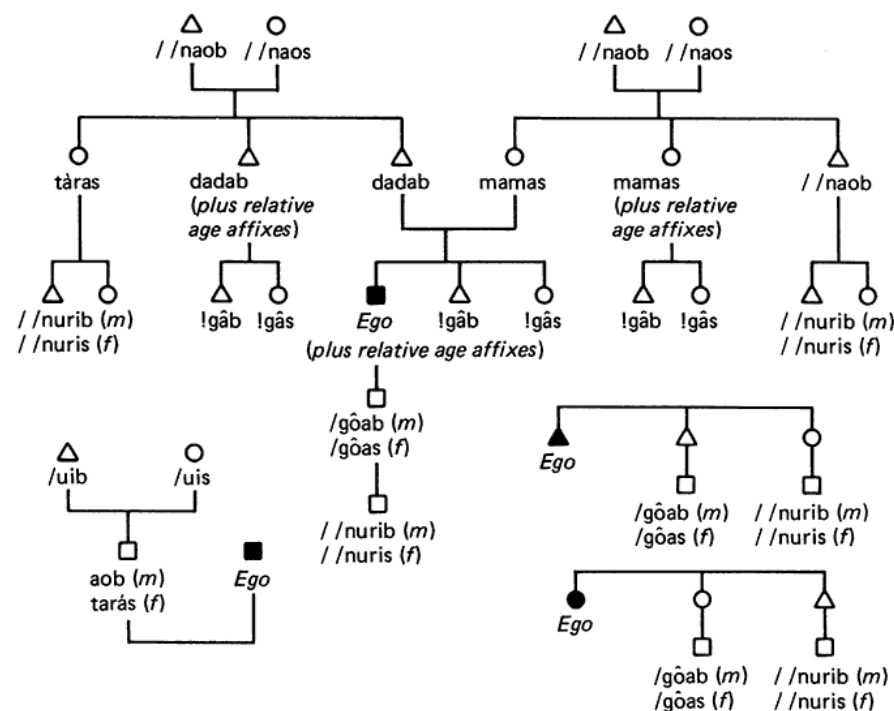
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Figure 10.3 Nama kinship terminology: basic structure



those of the same genealogical level are *//nuri-*. Only those relatives in a *//nuri-gu* relationship (as they are designated reciprocally) are marriageable. From the available evidence it appears that in earlier times cross-cousins on either side were in this class, as they are today, although as with the Korana there are indications in the literature that matrilineal marriage was 'preferred' (see Barnard 1975: 11-16). The Nama mother's brother (*//naob*) was the object of intense joking behaviour, including obligatory cattle-snatching and the threat of wife-snatching on the part of a sister's son towards his mother's brother. Among the Nama, this relationship is known as *//nuri//as* or *//nuri//ab* (literally '*//nuri* exchange').

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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